



D-Link DMP 100: Great looks with decent performance and price

just one-trick ponies, which did nothing more than play MP3 files stored on a memory card and looked monumental as compared to the Nomads and the Rios of today. Nowadays, these devices are capable of far more than just playing simple 128 Kbps MP3s; they can act as voice recorders, FM radios, a DJ's mixers and loop creators and even digital cameras. Not only this, there is a wide variety of mediums you can choose from, depending on what your requirements are. You can choose the compact and robust solid-state memory based players, the CD-MP3 players, the hard drive based players, or the removable disk players like the Hip Zip from Iomega.

They've also become far more affordable—you can grab a portable MP3 player for the price of a hi-end Discman. Though prices are still a bit too high in India as compared to the West, you can expect the prices to come down dramatically as the sales go up. But for now, let's see what the market has to offer.

The Players

We tested a total of 10 MP3 devices. These players come in many different flavours, ranging from the straightforward no-frills MP3 player such as the Rio 300, to the Kodak MC3 that acts as a digital camera and a video recorder too. But then, instead of rolling all around, we focussed on the core function, that is playing music while on the move. This reduced the total number of qualifiers in the competition to eight, excluding the Kodak MC3 and the Philips MP3/VCD hi-fi system.

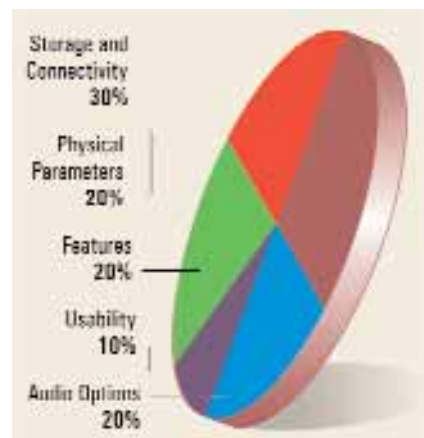
The Rio 300 is the most inexpensive MP3 player in the Indian market at Rs 9,280, which is still considerably higher than what most people can afford when it comes to portable audio equipment. A wide variety of inexpensive portable MP3 players are available in the US and Singapore that cost less than half the price of the Rio 300 and offer better features. However, we are yet to see these players in India. The same goes for the Nomad Jukebox that has been priced at more than twice the rate at which it sells for elsewhere.

We had our doubts when it came to CD-MP3 players. Any product that incorporates moving parts and a removable medium is bound to be less reliable and robust than a solid state device, and won't offer the same level of performance either. However, the eXpanium CD-MP3 player from Philips changed all of this. We expected it to skip, it didn't; we expected it to break open when thrown down from 5 feet onto a hard floor but it didn't; we expected it to be a real battery guzzler, it wasn't.

CDs are the cheapest medium to store data on nowadays, and with CD-burning shops all around the place, it's not very difficult to get those MP3s on your hard drive onto CDs. This

TEST PROCESS

While testing the MP3 players, we looked at five main parameters: storage and connectivity, physical parameters, usability, features and audio options. Within storage and connectivity, we noted the total storage space, the memory type and the connectivity type. The physical parameters included aspects such as size, ergonomics, display panel, build quality and looks. Usability measured the ease of use and display information, while



features checked for the presence of voice recording, FM Radio, Firmware upgrade, the formats supported and scope for future expandability. In terms of quality, we looked at the maximum power output, audio reproduction accuracy, audio consistency and play-time.

The weightages for the parameters are as shown in the pie chart.

very obviously makes a CD-MP3 player the most practical choice for almost anyone who wants to play MP3s on the move.

When better players such as the Rio-Volt and the AVC Soul player are introduced in India at reasonable prices, this scenario is bound to change even more, and make the whole deal a lot more practical. So let's go see how the current breed being sold in India fared in our tests.

Storage and connectivity

How many MB of music can you store? Is the audio storage medium robust enough to endure the day-to-day usage? Does it take too much time to transfer audio to the device? All these questions are as important as the audio quality or the usability of the device. The more music you can store, the longer is your playtime and you can carry that much more entertainment with you.

Well, the **Nomad Jukebox** is the ruler of this



More Info on the test process and the products tested,
Surge the MP3 music, check out **Playware & Mindware**

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